

Developmental Psychology -- Term Paper

Background: Pre-birth

Mom and Dad had been married for three years until she phoned him at work one unsuspecting day with the surprising news of her pregnancy; yes, surprising indeed. Dad, at the age of forty, and Mom thirty-one, the thought of another child, created an existential moment for the two. They both came from previous failed marriages, with Dad gaining three children from his ex-wife and Mom two from her ex-husband.

Together they housed a ‘family’ of seven under one roof, although it wasn’t quite a true family in Mom’s words-- “We were like two households under one roof” she told me in an impromptu interview over the phone. Dad married her partly because he wanted a mother figure for his children after a nasty divorce with their mother, although he wasn’t able to reciprocate the same fatherly actions toward Mom’s two boys. This was an “irritating” issue for Mom, as she wanted a true blending of families. According to her, Dad would take his biological kids out for fun activities without even inviting her kids and was able to buy them expensive gifts, while Mom was incapable of providing to the same extent. This phenomenon was not isolated to their family dynamic, however. Indeed, step-parents often favor their biological children over stepchildren in many blended family situations (Becker, Salzburger, Lois, & Nauck, 2013), though was not self-apparent for my father, considering this was his first remarriage. Today, he is married to another woman named Penny, who, after years of family therapy, have learned to treat her children as if they were his. Penny, in return, has treated me as a son and I have felt a barrier become removed between us.

With Mom's two boys rooming together on one side of the house, and Dad's three kids on the other side, it embodied the lack of cohesion, emotional responsiveness, and communication between them as siblings...or whatever they considered each other as. Ashley, Dad's youngest daughter, resented Mom for stealing her father's attention. Ashley found refuge in our sister, Kristy, who was the closest mother figure she had, became 'parentified' in some capacity toward Ashley since their biological mother was mostly absent.

Beginnings: My Arrival

November 17th, 1998, was the day Mom and Dad's 'surprise' was delivered to Flagler Hospital in St. Augustine, Florida. I was born to parents who could've been old enough to be my grandparents, and to siblings that could've been my parents, with the closest generation gap being 18 years. "You were loved by everyone; you were the 'tie' that merged our two families," Mom said. My birth was the common thread between my half-siblings and allowed Ashley to embrace Mom in a different light.

Due to the wide age gap between me and my siblings, I developed an affinity for being around older people as opposed to my generation. My brothers and sisters tried to involve me in their lives as much as possible, consequently making my years in primary school a challenge when relating to my peers. As I've gotten older, though, gaining friends has become more natural and easy for me.

Disequilibrium: A Trail of Divorce

Divorce rates are higher in second marriages than the first, and this was certainly evident with Mom and Dad. When I was only four years old and about to enter Pre-K they decided to separate. I suppose my 'tie' upon their two families withered away. Mom told me I adapted well to the divorce initially because I was entering school, which was a timely distraction for me.

Behind the scenes, though, Mom and Dad “fought” over who gets access to me more, as is true for most couples following a divorce (Maes, De Mol, & Buysse, 2012). Although my initial reaction may have been mild, the effects were to be realized years later.

“I overfocused on you after the divorce”, Dad tells me over the phone. “I saw what it did to Ricky, Kristy, and Ashley and I didn’t want you to go through what they endured. It was my natural reaction to the feelings of guilt, loss, and anxiety; I just wanted the absolute best for you.” Dad took me everywhere he went--to work, to football games, to baseball games, on dates with new women who were to be his wife. There could have been a hint of *enmeshment* involved, a term first coined by Salvador Minuchin who describes it as overinvolvement and fusion between two people (Kassop, 1987). Despite it giving feelings of belongingness, enmeshment within a family structure it has the potential to disrupt the development of one’s self-identity. The distinction between each others’ feelings may become blurred, as one person’s problem becomes the other and vice versa. Over time, however, this enmeshment settled down. Today I still may feel the effects of it, since I often find myself seeking to please him in everything I do. Disappointing my Dad would be the worst punishment for me. He never had to use corporal punishment on me, as one ‘look’ from him was all that was necessary to set me straight. I’m not claiming that this persistent drive for my father’s approval *is* a consequence of his involvement after the divorce; however, it certainly is not impossible.

Mom remarried shortly after the divorce and stayed with this man for roughly ten years. His name was Chan and unlike most stepfathers, he actively participated in my childrearing. “Chan treated you like you were one of his own”, Mom recalled. He was the only man I envisioned my mother being with, as I was too young to remember her time with Dad. While Dad was out searching for a new wife I felt like my life with Mom and Chan was much more

stable. She told me that I was alternating between her and Dad's house every other day. When I started developing reading literacy problems at school they made a mutual decision to keep me in one place for the majority of the time.

For several years I hated visiting Dad as a kid because he was constantly on the move to find a new wife. Mom told me Dad would be sitting on her porch to pick me up, but I would run and hide. Mom never forced me to go. I primarily lived with Mom and Chan for a big chunk of time until they divorced. At that time, Dad had finally found a new wife, so I began to settle in with him, plus, he bought me a dog as a bribe to visit him since nothing else worked. This pattern of attachment was based on which parent could give me more stability in housing and emotion. To this day, I find myself 'running' to the other parent when things get sour between me and the other one, a tell-tale triangulation between us. Perhaps this triangulation is a continuation of the instability I experienced as a kid, where I cope with distress by escaping my current situation.

After Mom split with Chan she went on the hunt for other men, and my world with her was uprooted once again. I had to visit several mental health counselors and one clinical psychologist to treat the anxiety that was creeping into my life. Having only entered middle school, I developed eye tics where I couldn't stop blinking. I had immense difficulty falling asleep most nights, had this obsessive (but irrational) fear of developing diabetes and had horrifying panic attacks where my throat felt as if it were closing up. While it is true that extreme anxiety is experienced by children through the process of divorce (Maes, De Mol, & Buysse, 2012), I can't say for certain that those symptoms were directly caused by the divorce. Today I still experience similar symptoms of that anxiety when I sense that my world is being 'shook up', and perhaps that is rooted in the long chain of divorces. I'm intolerant of unpredictability and often distressing feelings of the uncertain continue to manifest themselves in somatic ways.

Differentiation: Polar Opposites

Mom and Dad were quite the opposite in many aspects. Her side of the family originally came from the deep valleys of West Virginia, where electricity was unheard of and water was only accessed through a well. Dad's side came from Hawthorne, Florida, but the culture among his side heavily regarded education. He had his doctorate and had been working in educational leadership for many years. When visiting each parent I especially noticed how their emotional reactivity was starkly contrasted. Mom's behavior seemed to be heavily influenced by her emotions. She would wear it like garments, instantaneously emitting emotional responses to any external stimulus she received. At times, I couldn't even be in the same room with her because I felt like I soaked up her mood like a sponge.

Dad was more cerebral in his approach to life, displaying more intellect than emotions in decision-making. He still knew how to recognize his feelings without letting them overcome his judgment, and was adept at teaching me how to not shy away from emotions. Today I would argue that I've acquired my father's ability to display emotional *differentiation*, or the ability to recognize one's emotions and cope with them in healthy ways (Lennarz, Lichtwarck-Aschoff, Timmerman, & Granic, 2018).

I always joke with him that I "act like Mom when I visit you and act like you when I visit Mom". This, in essence, could be a demonstration of polarization depending on which parent is around as if I'm subconsciously recreating the original dynamic of what their marriage was like together.

In Sum: Current Times

Murray Bowen (1972) posited that individuals' behavior must not be viewed in a vacuum. Rather, he or she should be considered through the context of their family--a *system*.

My family has consistently evolved throughout my life thus far with ever-changing systems. When I felt like things were beginning to settle and remain steady, the rug was often pulled from under me. This makes adapting to new situations extremely uncomfortable for me now, but I feel as though I have had adequate experience with it. Being that my family is so large and diverse, it has given me an advantage in learning to be more open-minded with other people. Mom's personality and side of the family were vastly different than Dad's. The men Mom married and dated were also quite the characters (although I think she was going through a midlife crisis), whereas Dad found a relatively solid remarriage. Penny's family is perhaps the most contrasting group of people I've been around, and yet they have gradually worked their way into my heart over the years. I am the product of many systems that have risen and fallen, but I'm content with this because there is no one else I would rather be.

References

- Becker, O. A., Salzburger, V., Lois, N., & Nauck, B. (2013). What narrows the stepgap? Closeness between parents and adult (step)children in Germany. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 75(5), 1130–1148. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12052>
- Bowen, M. (1972). Family therapy and family group therapy. In *Group treatment of mental illness*. E. P. Dutton.
- Kassop, M. (1987). Salvador Minuchin: A sociological analysis of his family therapy theory. *Clinical Sociology Review*, 5, 158–167.
- Lennarz, H. K., Lichtwarck-Aschoff, A., Timmerman, M. E., & Granic, I. (2018). Emotion differentiation and its relation with emotional well-being in adolescents. *Cognition and Emotion*, 32(3), 651–657. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02699931.2017.1338177>

Maes, s. J., De Mol, J., & Buysse, A. (2012). Children's experiences and meaning construction on parental divorce: A focus group study. *Childhood: A Global Journal of Child Research*, 19, 266--279.